

C11 Communicating Complex or Sensitive Information

Pillar	Communication	Difficulty	Level 2
Time Required	45-55 minutes	Group Size	4-10
Mode	Team facilitation or manager self-work	Format	In-person or remote
Prerequisites	C9 (Conflict Communication) helpful for sensitive message delivery	CLOVER ERA Trigger	Misunderstood instructions, poor feedback reception, confusion around change initiatives, complex information not landing

Why This Works

THE NEUROSCIENCE

The brain has a limited capacity for processing new, complex information. Cognitive load theory (Sweller, 1988) shows that when a message exceeds working memory capacity (roughly 4-7 chunks of new information), comprehension collapses. The listener nods but retains almost nothing.

Sensitive information adds emotional processing on top of cognitive processing. When someone hears news that affects them personally (performance feedback, organisational changes, role adjustments), the amygdala activates and competes with the prefrontal cortex for processing resources. The result: they hear the emotional signal ("this is bad/good/scary") but miss the actual content.

Effective delivery of complex or sensitive information requires reducing cognitive load (simplify, structure, sequence) AND managing emotional load (empathy, timing, space for processing).

The Exercise

Phase 1: The Complexity Strip-Down (15 minutes)

Each participant selects a piece of genuinely complex information from their own work: a technical concept, a process change, a multi-layered update. They write it down as they would normally communicate it.

Then apply three filters:

- Strip jargon: replace every technical term with plain language.
- Reduce to three points: what are the three things the listener absolutely must understand? Cut everything else.

7. Lead with the 'so what': start with why this matters to the listener, not with the background.

Share the before and after versions with a partner. The partner rates: "On a scale of 1-5, how much clearer is the simplified version?"

Phase 2: The Sensitive Message Framework (15 minutes)

For delivering sensitive information, teach the CARE framework:

- Context: why you're having this conversation ("I wanted to talk to you about...")
- Acknowledge: name the emotional impact before delivering the content ("I know this may be difficult to hear")
- Reality: deliver the information clearly and completely. Do not drip-feed or soften to the point of ambiguity.
- Enable: provide next steps, support, or space for processing ("Here's what happens next" or "Take whatever time you need to process this")

Practise in pairs with a pre-prepared sensitive scenario (e.g., delivering news of a project being cancelled, giving feedback on underperformance, communicating a role change).

Phase 3: Receiving Complex/Sensitive Information (10 minutes)

WHAT TO SAY

"We've focused on delivery. Now let's talk about receiving. When someone gives you complex or sensitive information, your brain's first job is processing the emotion, not the content. So: what's the best thing a listener can do?"

"Three things. First, resist the urge to respond immediately. Second, say what you heard: 'Let me make sure I understand.' Third, ask for time if you need it: 'I need to sit with this. Can we talk again tomorrow?' All three are completely acceptable."

Facilitation Notes

Situation	Response
The complexity strip-down produces oversimplified messages that lose critical nuance	"There's a difference between simple and simplistic. The goal is not to dumb it down but to make the essential information accessible. If nuance matters, add it after the core message lands, not before."
Someone delivers a sensitive practice message too harshly	Coach in real time: "The content was clear. The delivery could use the 'Acknowledge' step. Before delivering the reality, name that this is hard to hear. That one sentence changes how the brain processes everything that follows."

Cross-Pillar Connections

Worksheet	Connection	Direction
C9: Conflict Communication	C11 teaches delivery of difficult messages. C9 handles what happens when the response is emotional or confrontational.	C11 before C9 for delivery skills; C9 for response skills
V1: Vulnerability Circle	Delivering sensitive information well requires trust. V1 builds that trust.	V1 before C11
C4: Information Distortion	Complex information is most vulnerable to distortion. C4 shows why; C11 teaches how to prevent it.	Complementary